The United Nations and the Contemporary Global Governance

Learning Objectives:

- Identify the roles and functions of the United Nations
- Explain the relevance of the state amid globalization
- Identify the challenges of global governance in the twenty-first century

Global Governance

Global governance or world governance is a movement towards political cooperation among transnational actors, aimed at negotiating responses to problems that affect more than one state or region.

There are many sources of global governance:

- States sign treaties and form organizations
- International non-governmental organizations (NGOs) can lobby individual states to behave in a certain way
- Powerful transnational corporations can likewise have tremendous effects on global labor laws, environmental legislation, and trade policy.

What is an International Organization?

IOs, the term is commonly used to refer to international intergovernmental organizations or groups that are primarily made up of member-states.

Powers of International Organizations

1. IOs, have the power of classification.
   - Can invent and apply categories, they create powerful global standards.

2. IOs, have the power to fix meanings
   - Various terms like security or development need to be well-defined. States, organizations, and individuals view IOs as a legitimate sources of information.

Powers of International Organizations

3. IOs, have the power to diffuse norms

- Norms are accepted codes of conduct that may not be strict law, but nevertheless produce regularity in behavior.

The United Nations is an intergovernmental organization that aims to:

- maintain international peace and security,
- develop friendly relations among nations,
- achieve international cooperation,
- and be a center for harmonizing the actions of nations.

United Nations (UN) 5 Organs/Bodies

1. General Assembly (GA)
2. Security Council (SC)
3. Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)
4. International Court of Justice
5. Secretariat

United Nations (UN) 5 Organs/Bodies

1. General Assembly (GA)

- Deliberative, policymaking and representative organ.
- Decisions on important questions, such as those on peace and security, admission of new members and budgetary matters, require a two-thirds majority of the General Assembly.
- Each year, elects a GA President to serve one-year term of office.

United Nations (UN) 5 Organs/Bodies

2. Security Council

- The GA elects ten of these 15 to two-year terms. The other Five- sometimes referred to as the Permanent (P5) China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States.
- Responsible for the maintenance of international peace and security.
- SC takes the lead in determining the existence of a threat to the peace or an act of aggression.
- With the SC's approval, military intervention may be deemed legal. This is an immense power.

United Nations (UN) 5 Organs/Bodies

3. Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

- The principal body for coordination, policy review, policy dialogue, and recommendations on social and environmental issues, as well as the implementation of internationally agreed development goals.

- Has 54 members elected for three-year terms.

United Nations (UN) 5 Organs/Bodies

4. International Court of Justice

- To settle, in accordance with international law, legal disputes submitted to it by states and to give advisory opinions referred to it by authorized United Nations organs and specialized agencies.
- SC may enforce the rulings of the ICJ, but this remains subject to the P5's veto power.
- Issues legal opinions;
- Renders judgment by relative majority. Its fifteen judges are elected by the UN General Assembly for nine-year terms.

- 1960s, the diplomat Salvador P. Lopez was chairman of the United Nation Commission on Human Rights .

United Nations (UN) 5 Organs/Bodies

5. UN Secretariat

- Secretary-General and tens of thousands of international UN staff members who carry out the day-to-day work of the UN as mandated by the General Assembly and the organization's other principal organs.

- Supports the other UN bodies administratively

Challenges of the United Nations

- The UN is not a world government, and it functions primarily because of voluntary cooperation from states.
- If states refuse to cooperate, the influence of the UN can be serverely circumscribed.
- Issues of security as mentioned, the UN Security Council is tasked with authorizing international acts of military intervention.
- Because of the P5's veto power, it is

Challenges of the United Nations

- Serbian Leader Slobodan Milosevic was committing acts of ethnic Muslim Albanians in the province of Yugoslavia.
- North Atlantic Treaty organization (NATO), led by the United States, sought SG authorization to intervene.
- However, China and Russia, threatened to veto any action.
- Russia has threatened to veto any

Challenges of the United Nations

- When the United States sought to invade Iraq in 2001, it claimed that Iraq’s Saddam Hussein had weapons of mass destruction (WMD) that threatened the world.
- However, UN members Russia, China, and France were unconvinced and vetoed the UN resolution for intervention, forcing the United States to lead a small “coalition of the willing” with its allies.

UN Today

- On 24 April 2020, the UN, uniting with many partners, launches the Access to COVID-19 Tools Accelerator
- On 1 March 2020, the UN released US$15 million
- On 23 March 2020, the Secretary - General called for an immediate global ceasefire.

Thank you for listening!